

list, now suspected to be living in Pakistan, such as Mumbai don Dawood Ibrahim, Lashkar-e-Toiba chief Hafeez Mohammed Saeed and Jaish-e-Mohammad head Maulana Masood Azhar. He further angered India by stating that he doubted if Ajmal Amir Kasab, the terrorist the Mumbai Police had caught alive, was a Pakistani and termed him a "a stateless individual". The cavalier denials came after the MEA summoned Pakistan High Commissioner Shahid Malik to register India's protest, issuing a demarche that said bilateral relations would be hit if Pakistan did not take verifiable action against terror groups in its territory.

Zardari's apparent defiance ratcheted up tensions between the two countries. External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee did not rule out using the military option, stating, "We are determined to

take the strongest possible measures to ensure that there is no repetition of such acts." Visibly concerned, the US Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice flew into Delhi in a bid to calm things down. She said, "Pakistan needs to act with resolve and urgency and cooperate fully and transparently." She then proceeded to Islamabad to turn on the pressure to get the leadership to cooperate with India.

With major powers demanding proof of Pakistan's complicity, India then launched a diplomatic offensive. "We have ample evidence of Pakistani involvement and it must demonstrate some concrete action on the ground," Mukherjee told INDIA TODAY. As a first step India has allowed agencies from countries like the US, the UK and Israel, whose nationals were killed in the Mumbai attacks, access to the intelligence information and even interrogation of the arrested terrorist to establish beyond doubt that there is clearly a link with Pakistan, and that a section of Pakistani establishment is involved.

Meanwhile, Indian intelligence agencies have laid their hands on what they think is damning information about Pakistan's complicity. It includes a purported conversation between a Pakistani army corps commander speaking to his counterpart in Rawalpindi after the Mumbai attacks. He was quoted as saying, "*Accha maza chakhaya in Hindustaniyon ko, ab dekhiye Hindustan kaise jalega*" (The Indians have been taught a lesson, now we will see how India will burn)." In another conversation, the agencies have intercepted a Lashkar-e-Toiba controller named Muzaffar speaking to a Lt colonel from the Pakistan Army at a location in Islamabad. This could as well be propaganda and the agencies would need to come up with proof as they did during the Kargil War.

In the first phase of its offensive, India hopes to build an international coalition against Pakistan-sponsored terrorism. Part of this initiative will be to press the US and other Security Council members to ensure that the comprehensive convention on terrorism at the UN, proposed by India, which has been on the backburner for the last 12 years because of differences on the definition of terrorism, is taken up by the world body on a priority. Besides it will press for a holistic implementation of UN Security Council resolutions 1373 and 1566 that deal with global action against terrorism besides seeking to expand its scope to seek punitive



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India's CHOICES

— International Coalition

Use coercive diplomacy through the US and UN but it may be a long haul

— Surgical Strikes

Attacks on training camps could drive the message of zero tolerance home but may invite retaliation

— Covert Operations

Capture and target terror masterminds but may lead to collateral damage and hostage situations

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